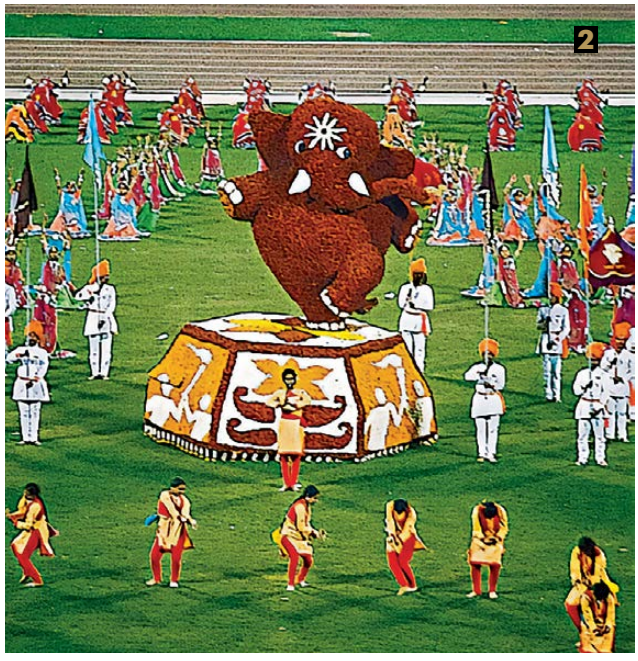


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BHAWAN SINGH

1. Prakash Padukone at the 1980 All-England Championships

2. The 1982 Asian Games mascot Appu at the opening ceremony

3. India vs Spain in the hockey final in Moscow, 1980

4. Bahadur Singh won the shotput gold at the Asiad

was given a lavish makeover, with new roads, flyovers and a spanking new Asiad village. For the first time, it was broadcast on television all over India in colour, and Appu, the baby elephant that was the Games mascot, caught everyone's imagination. A marvelling country was gripped by Asiad fever. The 16-day event saw 5,000 athletes from 33 countries; India returned its best medal tally of 57, a record that stood till 2010. Gold medal winners like Charles Borromeo (men's 800m), M.D. Valsamma (women's 400m hurdles) Bahadur Singh Chauhan (men's shotput) and the women's hockey team emerged as new superstars.

In 1980 came that rare event for India—a world-beating performance in an individual sport. Prakash Padukone's triumph at the 1980 All-England Championships and his ascent to World No. 1 in badminton that year was a milestone and presaged India's current heavyweight status. Though India won the 1975 Hockey World Cup, the national game was in some decline, hastened by the adoption of astroturf. A rare hurrah came in the 1980 Olympics, when India beat Spain in the final to win its last hockey gold. But then, this was a truncated field, as the US and other nations (including Pakistan, West Germany and Australia) boycotted the Moscow Games. ■



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